

# ***The Social Radars***

## **S1: Brian Chesky, Co-Founder & CEO of Airbnb**

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Jessica: I'm Jessica Livingston, and Carolynn Levy and I are The Social Radars. In this podcast we talk to some of the most successful founders in Silicon Valley about how they did it. Carolynn and I have been working together to help thousands of startups at Y Combinator for almost 20 years. Come be a fly on the wall as we talk to founders and learn their true stories.

Today we're talking with Brian Chesky, co-founder and CEO of Airbnb. YC funded Airbnb in 2009 when the company was at death's door. During YC we watched the founders work frantically to get growth started and turn Airbnb into the rocket ship that it is today. Learn what it takes to come up with an idea so weird that it seems like it will never work and then make it work.

Brian: Hey, all. How you doing?

Carolynn: Hey, Brian.

Jessica: We are so excited to have you, Brian, on the show today. Thank you for coming. What I really have been thinking about as we led up to this is that I really would love to do a bit of a wander down memory lane with you about how Airbnb got started and its early days participating in Y Combinator. But I'm curious to ask you, because I've read about or heard about how you've been renting your house out, are you in your house right now?

Brian: Yes. I'm in my house in San Francisco. I live near Dolores Park and I had a guest, actually two guests, who stayed with me this past weekend. And actually, funny enough, the guy was a YC founder.

Carolynn: Oh, no way. Can I ask who? Are you allowed to say who?

Brian: Yeah, yeah, Joseph Nelson. By the time this is out, there'll probably be a blog post that he has posted.

Jessica: And he's an alum or he is in the current batch?

Brian: Oh, sorry, he's an alum. I think he was in YC 2020, that crazy year.

Carolynn: Oh, yeah.

Brian: During YC. Yeah, and he has like 30 employees, it's computer visioning tools for developers. And yeah, it was really awesome. I think a quick, obviously we'll tell the story of the company, but one of the things that makes Airbnb different is, I didn't start it because I love traveling and I wanted a better way to travel. We started it because we loved hosting, actually, and we love inviting people in our world.

Jessica: I know.

Brian: I don't even really think of us as a travel company. I think in some ways we're in the travel sector, but we're really different than most other travel companies. We're really more about hosting and community, and so I wanted to do it again, and I had this crazy idea that I'd do what I used to do, which was have somebody in my house with me in another bedroom. I have a guest room right when you walk in the house. And so I was trying to think, what's a good theme for the guest room? And I figured if somebody wants to stay with me, they're probably really interested in the history of Airbnb. So I created a little Airbnb memorabilia room, and I have literally the original receipt from the first air bed that we inflated in October of 2007. I have old photos, even pre-Y Combinator, where we're working out of our three-bedroom apartment, the old cereal boxes that were blooming together.

And so I get to show him around. Then we had dinner. It turned out to be a really late night, where he, me, and his girlfriend just talked and I was giving him my two cents on how to go from 30 employees and beyond. I think there were some insights that I was able to share with him. For example, I think there's a sense when founders start growing to let go of a lot of details. And I just said, "You should stay in the details." I think a lot of what people tell you about running a company is actually incorrect. That's not the way founders run a company. So we did that. I took him on a tour of the office. I made him my famous Chesky's chips, a family recipe that I got off Google.

Jessica: Wait a second. When you're hosting someone in your house, are you agreeing to cook them dinner and give them tours and give them all of your time?

Brian: Yes.

Carolynn: And secret family recipes, apparently.

Brian: I'm not a very good cook. I can cook an egg, but I'm more of a baker also. I'll just say a baker, I bake one thing and it's the simplest thing anyone in the world can bake, it's a chocolate chip cookie. But I do that, and I got them groceries and we made food together. And then yeah, I took them on a tour to the office. It was maybe a two-hour tour, and I basically did some version of the Y Combinator talk I do, but in the office. So it's like a living experience, kind of like a tour guide, but you're walking through. But you're the person who experienced it telling it firsthand, and it definitely gets your heart rate up. Because you can feel the sense of all the craziness that we went through over the last 15 years.

Jessica: I think you need to serve a bag of Captain Crunch and rip it open for them.

Brian: Yes, exactly. Exactly.

Jessica: And have them eat with their hands.

Brian: Exactly.

Jessica: I'll make you tell that story, but can Paul and I come stay with you?

Brian: I would love to have Paul and you come stay with me. I'd love to.

Jessica: I love this.

Brian: Well, then it'll be a reverse office hours where you and PG can give me feedback again, just like the early days.

Jessica: All right, this is a good segue then. This is a good segue.

Brian: Yeah, let's do it.

Jessica: Like I said, I want to go deep dive, back into when you got started. Because I need to say, you didn't start when you applied to YC, you had already been around for a year.

Brian: Yeah.

Jessica: So I want to go back to how you love being a host and how that's in your marrow, kind of thing, being a host. That is how Airbnb got started, because tell the story how there was the conference and you needed to make the money, and all the hotels were sold out in the Bay area.

Brian: Yeah, the story actually starts even before we started a company. I would say the story starts a couple decades ago. Because I went to the Rhode Island School of Design, which is not a typical path to somebody starting a tech company, although PG I think went to RISD for a short period of time, obviously.

Jessica: Yeah, he did.

Brian: And I went with my co-founder, my now co-founder, Joe Gebbia, and I remember on the day of graduation Joe says to me, he says, "Brian, I think one day we're going to start a company together." Now, the thing to know about Joe and I was that we were very entrepreneurial on campus at art school, and I ran the hockey team and Joe ran the basketball team. We had the hardest marketing challenge in the world. How do you get art students to come to a sports game? And so we were friendly rivals that at the end of graduation decided to team up. We didn't know what we were going to do. But he had the premonition. And I said okay.

But I was in major industrial design, so I moved to Los Angeles. And I'm working, I think my starting salary was 40 something thousand dollars, \$45,000 a year working for a very small company as an industrial designer. And basically we worked with small clients that didn't have the budget to go with a really large design firm like an IDEO at the time, which turned out to be a blessing because I got to basically work with startups and I was able to develop startup instincts of, how do you design and bring something to market? And just as a fun fact before I tell the stunning story, I actually ended up on a reality TV show against my will.

Carolynn: What? Really?

Brian: Oh, yeah, yeah. During 2006, basically you remember in the mid-2000s probably the biggest TV show in the mid-2000s was American Idol, and Simon Cowell created it and it was this huge thing.

Carolynn: Yeah.

Jessica: Yeah.

Brian: So Simon Cowell had this idea, which really became the precursor to Shark Tank, called American Inventor, where any person with an idea for an invention could come and you'd win \$50,000. The \$50,000 you'd use to hire a design firm to build a prototype. And then if you won, I think then they would produce your product. And I ended up getting matched with a guy named Joseph Zaffuto, who had an idea for a better toilet seat. And my boss is like, "You're going to do this," which was kind of interesting. And so I'm like, "All right," because I had to do it, because if I didn't do it, the firm wouldn't get the business because we were so small. There was really no one else to give the job, too. So before I knew it, I was designing a toilet seat on national television for a magician.

Jessica: A magician?

Carolynn: Oh my goodness.

Jessica: I had no idea.

Brian: Yeah.

Jessica: What happened to it?

Carolynn: Yeah.

Brian: Believe it or not, it was not as successful as the iPod or the iPhone.

Carolynn: What?

Brian: Yeah, believe it or not, it was just a toilet seat that, I don't think it ever got manufactured, but it got a little TV exposure. It was kind of funny. They tend to pick really colorful personalities for reality TV. So as you can imagine, this person was quite colorful, to say the least.

Carolynn: The magician?

Brian: Yes, the magician.

Jessica: Was the toilet seat magical? What was the gist of this toilet seat?

Brian: The gist of the toilet seat, well, it's hard to talk about toilet seats without people saying, "Okay, move on." But it was basically like his mother had a compromised immune system, and toilet seats, there's a lot of bacteria that can spread, and so he wanted to make a more hygienic toilet seat. And the issue was it became kind of a gizmo. No one really wants to take a crap in the iPod. You want to ...

Jessica: Yeah, yeah.

Brian: Really having a real sensibility for appropriate use of technology. And when a latch just works or something physical works, it's probably a good lesson. But anyway, so I'm designing this product and designing all these different products, and I'm just like, "It's interesting." But I remember one day, this is like 2007 now, my life is like a metaphor. I'm in a road in a car, and the road in front of me looks exactly like the road behind me. And I'm like, "Well, if I just keep doing this, this will be the rest of my life. And it's a good life for someone, but not for me. This is not my life." And at that time I also was really getting into Silicon Valley. I remember I read the biography of Walt Disney, and I got really inspired by that, and Steve Jobs was, the iPhone had just come out, it was announced. And it felt like the gears of the world that were turning were in San Francisco.

And one day I got a package in the mail at my office, and it's a seat cushion in the shape of a human buttocks with a handle on it, and the product is called Crip Buns. It actually is a really well-designed product that my co-founder Joe created that ended up in the Museum of Modern Art gift shop. So it was a very well-designed product. He basically sent a note that said, "I started this company," and at the end of the note, it basically said, "Come to San Francisco." That was like if [inaudible 00:11:05].

Jessica: "And here's a cushion for you in the shape of buns"?

Brian: Yes.

Jessica: For your road trip?

Brian: Well, perhaps, but the thing that was astounding was, he made a product. When you go to design school, you're making basically products that aren't real forever, right? They're all exercises. Nothing is real. Nothing's getting in production. So to make something real that's in a store that people sell is kind of astounding. It's like breaking down a wall between you and the world. It's amazing. And it's the ultimate thing that any creator wants to do, is they want to create something for somebody else to be able to use. And so I thought, "This is amazing. This is the time, I have to go." I go to work one day, I quit my job, and my boss is just kind of surprised, my coworkers are surprised. I'm living in a house with three friends that I actually convinced to move across the country. So you can imagine, this seemed a kind of crazy and impulsive move.

But I had been thinking about starting a company and doing something for a long time, and I had the sense that what was important in the world was happening in San Francisco at that time. And so one day I go in, quit my job, I pack everything in the back

of an old Honda Civic, and I drive up, this is October, I'm going to guess first week of October 2007. I get to San Francisco and I'm told the rent is \$1,150, and I don't have enough money to pay rent. And so Joe and I, this is a problem, San Francisco was expensive even back then. I had hardly any savings.

But it turns out that something was going on that weekend. And what was going on that weekend was that there was this design conference that we were going to go to, an industrial design conference, and it was in San Francisco every whatever, few decades. So it was completely crazy that that weekend there was a design conference. And all the hotels on the conference website that they were recommending were sold out. And so that's when we had an idea. Joe actually said, "What if we just turned our house into a bed and breakfast for the design conference?" But unfortunately we didn't have any beds, but Joe had three air beds. And so we inflated those.

Jessica: Well, you had an extra room, right? You had an extra room.

Brian: We had an extra room, yes, we had an extra room. And so we basically got these three air beds. We inflated them and realized what we created was not a bed and breakfast, but an air bed and breakfast. So kind of like a budget bed and breakfast that was pop-up for young kids. And that was where Airbnb comes from, [airbedandbreakfast.com](http://airbedandbreakfast.com). By the way, if you had ever asked me, would I have then told that story 1,000 times since then, I never would have thought possible. I would have never imagined that. But here I am still telling that story because of what happened next. And I thought we would have some young kids stay with us.

Carolynn: Backpackers.

Brian: Yeah, young backpackers, probably from LA. That's my assumption, guys. And we ended up having three people from totally different demographics. We had a 35-year-old woman from Boston. I never thought a woman would stay with me. A 45-year-old father of five from Utah, who was Mormon. And we had a 30-year-old originally from India. So essentially we had these three people from all walks of life, Michael, Kat, and Amal. They ended up staying with us, and something happened. They definitely saved money and they found a place to stay. But when they stayed with us, there was something that was significantly more important that happened. They got to feel like they were a designer in the city of San Francisco. And we basically took them around the city. We went to with them to parties. We took them to get burritos in the Mission. I drove one of them down to Stanford to go to the D school, the design school.

We just went around and we did stuff. And they got to experience living in San Francisco like a local and I got to experience making money to hang out with people. And I thought, "This is kind of fun." And it seemed crazy after we did it. What seemed crazy was that this didn't exist already. I was like, "Wow, this literally doesn't exist." And it started seeming kind of crazy. Why do people stay in hotels? Actually, and not to say they shouldn't exist, but it seemed kind of crazy. We have these things called homes. We live in them, but then when we travel, we don't stay in them. We stay in these other structures created and dedicated for them.

And it seemed like it was created because no one had found a system to get two people to trust one another in a way to stay in their home. And so we realized, if we can solve this, basically this trust problem, make it easy, leverage the latest of what was at the time latest technology, this would be an idea that would spread around the world. And I remember saying, "This is going to be huge. One day thousands of people are going to do this." That was my scale of what was big.

Jessica: Thousands.

Carolynn: Thousands of people.

Jessica: You knew there was something to it though, because you yourself were doing it.

Brian: I thought there'd be a movement, but to me 1,000 people ever would have been a movement. I had no sense of scale. Today it's been used more than a billion times. If you'd told me more than a billion times in nearly every country in the world that a stranger is staying with another stranger, tonight around the world a few million people will literally stay together. Never in history would that have been possible before a platform like that. But we ended up doing things that seemed crazy at the time. And now I'll say them and they're like, "Oh, whatever." But we said both sides are going to have profiles. Back then no one had a profile, like Craigslist.

Jessica: Yeah.

Brian: We said that both sides are going to leave reviews for each other after they stay. So it's this currency of trust. And you can only leave a review, not TripAdvisor or Yelp, only if you make a booking. And we're going to handle all the payments through the system. Now, at the time no one had done this. If you went on eBay, you had to pay through PayPal, but they sent you to paypal.com. It wasn't a very integrated experience. Etsy sent you to PayPal. So there really wasn't this idea that you would hit this button, you'd pay another person, this company would hold money. That whole model basically didn't exist. And now it seems like there's a lesson here, which is, it seems obvious now, not crazy, but the ideas that seem obvious now are completely terrifying, counterintuitive because they require you to think differently about every single thing. You have to think from first principles. I remember somebody once saying, "Brian, don't worry about people stealing your idea. If it's any good, everyone will dismiss it." And that was actually the story for the first year.

So we ended up launching, we had three people stay with us. We realized there's a bigger idea here, but we didn't know what to do next. And so I asked Joe, I said, "Well, who's the best engineer you know?" He said, "Well, my old roommate Nate is." Nate was a computer science major from Harvard. He was actually in the same class as Zuckerberg, so that same kind of crew. And we got together and we said, "What if you can build a website where you could book someone's home the way you could book a hotel anywhere in the world?" And little did I know how hard it was going to be.

Jessica: Hang on, though. You learned the hard way about the payment system. I remember this.

Brian: Yes.

Jessica: 'Cause I remember, was it at South by Southwest? You were traveling to Austin and you stayed with someone and they were like, "Okay, could you pay us now?" It was super awkward, right?

Brian: Yeah, actually I can bring this story to Y Combinator, because this is where Y Combinator gets involved.

Jessica: Okay.

Brian: So I'm living at Rouse Street in San Francisco, and we have three bedrooms. And after the founding weekend, our empty bedroom, we end up getting a roommate, and I think we got the roommate on Craigslist. But the roommate, this guy named Phil, happened to work for a Y Combinator company called Justin.tv.

Jessica: Aha.

Brian: Yes. And so people who know today would know that Justin.tv was essentially the precursor to Twitch, and it was Michael Seibel, Justin Com, Emmett Shearer, and Kyle Voy, very notable Y Combinator founders. And so Phil was at that company, and I was like, "What's Y Combinator?" So I was like, "This seems a really interesting thing." So we were completely fascinated. And so Phil was going to go to South by Southwest. So now this is like six months later, five months later.

So the founding weekend, October 2007. We go home the holidays, we come back, we get Nate together, and we decide we're going to build a website. Originally it was going to be basically air beds for conferences, actually. And so we asked, "What's the biggest conference in America that every tech person's going to?" And in 2008 that was South by Southwest.

Jessica: Yes.

Brian: So, we said, "All right, we're going to go to South by Southwest." So Joe and I decided to go to South by Southwest. We launched for South by Southwest, we got an article in Mashable, and it was probably 10 sentences in Mashable. There were maybe two comments. And I thought we made it. I told my mom a blog wrote about us. Honestly at this point I thought we were the Beatles.

Jessica: You're done.

Brian: I'm like, "This is a movement. We're like the Beatles. We've made it." But it turns out, yeah, I think maybe a few people had seen it. More people see a coupon at a grocery store. We end up launching for South by Southwest, and we end up getting two bookings that weekend. And I was one of the two bookings.

Carolynn: Oh, no.



Jessica: Okay.

Brian: Yeah. And then there was this other girl named Laurel. When you actually have so few customers, you study them. You're like, "Who are you, and is there another person like you? 'Cause if there is, I can double my business." And so it didn't really work. People weren't really interested. They thought it was kind of crazy. But I ended up using it in Austin, Texas. I stayed with this PhD student originally from Vietnam, University of Texas Austin PhD student. And he literally took this site more seriously than I did. He had this giant double-decker air bed with towels laid out and a mint, and his girlfriend was making me a traditional Vietnamese dinner.

Carolynn: That's awesome.

Brian: And I thought, "Oh my God." The first night, by the way, we didn't handle payments. So the first version we didn't handle money. Handling money made everything significantly more complicated. So we thought it'll just be kind of like Craigslist. And then he asked me kind of awkwardly that night, innocently, "Just quick question." I said, "Yeah." He goes, "How do I get paid?" And I go, "Oh my God, I haven't paid him." And I didn't have any money. I go, "Oh, I'll go to an ATM tomorrow and I'll pay you." So, then the next night I come back home, he has another dinner waiting for me, and all of a sudden I realize, "Oh my God, I forgot to get money."

Carolynn: No.

Brian: And so I think it was the last night or the second to last night and I'm like, "Oh my God, I've got to figure out where to go to get money." And at one point I remember he admitted later to thinking, "Wow." I was worried he was thinking, "Wow, did this guy just build a website ..."

Jessica: Yeah.

Brian: "... to basically freeload off of his user base?"

Jessica: Freeload.

Brian: Which is kind of a funny idea. And I also realized exchanging cash with a stranger in their house generally is not the kind of business I want to be in. Usually that that's associated to less regulated businesses. And so I wanted to basically have a payment system, not to have a business model, because back then it was, believe it or not, uncool to make money. It was actually, my recollection is 2007, 2008 it was almost like a negative signal if you had revenue because you just had an association to being closer to a brick and mortar business. It felt less like a tech company. And Facebook was taking over the world, and at this point I don't think they had a meaningful amount of revenue. And so everyone wanted to do a social network. Social networks in 2008 was AI today. It was all anyone was talking about. And imagine the company saying, "We have a revenue model for AI."

They're like, "No, no, we're just focused on technology." They're not really focused on that. So we ended up wanting to have a payment system, not realizing that ended up becoming our business model. And then something else happened during Y Combinator, which is, I ended up basically checking out of my Airbnb. I'm about to go to the airport, and all of a sudden I get a call from Phil, my roommate, saying, "Hey, I'm going to come to Austin, Texas. Stay another night." And I said, "But I already checked that on my Airbnb. I can't do that." And he goes, "Don't worry, I'm coming. My aunt, she's got a mansion outside of Austin. We're going to go there." And so I stay another night. I never hear from Phil. And I'm like, "Oh my God." And I already gave the keys back, and then my host ended up going on vacation.

So now we have two listings. One of them is gone on vacation and I don't know where to go. So I ended up having this weird moment where I went to a hotel, a lobby, but I didn't have enough money to sleep in the hotel and get a plane ticket back. So I ended up using the backpack as a pillow. And all of a sudden I have this dream in the lobby. In my dream my roommate is standing over me and all of a sudden I hear a voice and somebody says, "Is that your roommate?" And it's Michael Seibel, and he's standing over me in a lit lobby in Austin, Texas. Michael Seibel tells me, "Come to stay with us for the night." And long story short, I end up pitching Michael Seibel Airbnb, the vision.

I don't think he totally understood the gap between what we were doing and my enthusiasm for we were going. And he basically said, "I know these people that can write \$20,000 checks for you over dinner." I didn't know what he was talking about. He said, "No, these people are angels." And I said, "Oh my God, this guy believes in angels. This is totally crazy." And he goes, "No, no, no angel investors." I'm like, "Oh, okay." And then Michael Seibel took us under his wing, Joe and I would meet with him each week. And that was the next chapter.

Jessica: Now, angel investors, this is very important, because before you did YC, and we'll get to that in a second, which I believe was your last chance, last hope of life for Airbnb. You spent a year trying to raise money from angels in Silicon Valley, and you got a lot of nos, right?

Brian: Yeah, yeah. We tried to raise \$150,000 at a \$1.5 million, I think, post money valuation. So, you would have gotten about 10% of the company for \$150,000. And Michael Seibel actually introduced us to maybe 10 investors and then Joe and I sourced another 10. So we probably pitched about 20 investors proactively and they all said no. And there were all different reasons why, but mostly I remember somebody said in slightly more polite words than this, "I love everything but you and your idea." Basically, designers don't start tech companies and strangers won't stay with other strangers.

We ended up meeting an investor at University Cafe, and I've told this story before, but he ends up, we sit at a table, he says, "I'll be right back." He goes to the counter, gets a strawberry smoothie, he's drinking the smoothie. I'm in the middle of the pitch. He's like, "Uh-huh, uh-huh," never lifts his head out of the straw. Straw is in his mouth the entire time. And halfway through the pitch he just gets up, walks away and leaves. Leaves the smoothie on the table. And I didn't quite know, I thought he was like, "I'll be

right back." I guess I misunderstood. And I've never heard from him ever again. So that was it.

Carolynn: Ever again.

Jessica: Did you ever see him again and say, "Dude, why'd you leave? Why did you just leave me hanging in the middle of ..."

Brian: No, no.

Jessica: You've never seen him.

Brian: No, I didn't. I think just to give some maybe possible lessons to this chapter of the story, number one, back then everyone thought the next hot company was going to be a social networking company. And now Facebook had already started. And yeah, there were some social networks that became popular after, but in the intervening four or five years, none of those companies became really successful. I think that a lot of investors tend to want to invest a little bit sometimes superficially in the trend, like, "Oh, this company's great. I want to invest in more companies like that," without realizing, well, actually there's usually going to be one really large company in maybe many of these spaces. There is one Amazon. Now, you want to get a return, you can have a bunch of companies.

And I think they miss the founder. I think that what you're really investing in the early days as a founder. I think a lot of founders, the big ideas are going to be kind of crazy at first. The truly disruptive ideas are going to sound crazy and almost implausible and like, "That will never work." And I love something, I don't know if it's Paul Graham who says it, or maybe you and Paul Graham, that says you have to have a unique insight. You either need to have a unique skill or a unique insight. I think we as a founding team had some unique skills. We were very entrepreneurial. We had done a lot before. Nate was highly technical, but Joe and I were really good at design and marketing. This was in many ways like a design problem. And I don't think that people saw it as a design problem, but it was, I felt like, and so I thought we were perfect for that kind of problem. So yeah, I think there were a lot of lessons there.

Jessica: I need to come back to the design thing in a second, but I quickly want to just touch on the smoothie where the investor just walked out, because I do tell other founders that story when I try to impress upon founders how difficult fundraising is and how thick your skin has to be and how you have to persevere through the most humiliating nos. And you, by the way, have just about the most energy and the most commitment, even in the face of craziness, of most founders we've ever funded. But I tell that story to try to inspire people. Everyone, even the most successful founders, have been told no early on.

Brian: Over and over. I think there's a little bit, I don't know quite why this happens, but most people like to tell the founding story with some nostalgia that, "We had this idea, it took off, and it worked." And that is maybe the story of some companies. My recollection is that's actually what happened with Facebook. But what is missing from these stories is

all the struggle that leads up to it. And for us it was a total struggle. Just to give you an example, and at a summary level, we have the idea one weekend. Some time goes by, we ship the first version of the product, two people use it, I'm one of the two. So then we ship another version. That barely works. We then get introduced to dozens of investors. None of them want to invest in the company.

We have no money. People think the idea is crazy, they're not enthusiastic. Most of this is the really early days, there's not a lot of belief in it. And even we as founders, we believed in it, but it was hard to stay focused on it every day. There just wasn't a lot of momentum. And we all had other things going on in our life. And then you know those binders that kids put baseball cards in as a kid? I don't think they have them any more, everything's digital now. But back when I was a kid, you had physical things. And we actually put credit cards in those binders. We racked up tens of thousands dollars of credit card debt.

And yeah, there was this crazy story where the Democratic and Republican conventions are coming up. We're basically still providing housing for conferences and conventions at this point. And so we said, "Let's provide housing for the DNC." We ended up getting 80 bookings. I thought we were huge. I'm like, "Now we're definitely the Beatles." And then the next weekend we have two bookings for the Republican convention. And then the next weekend there was no business. And I realized if only there was a Democratic convention every week we'd have a business. But there isn't.

Jessica: Right.

Brian: And so what do we do? So we thought, "We're Air Bed and Breakfast. The air beds aren't selling. Let's sell breakfast cereal." Of course, intuitively. And at this point I remember Michael Siebel getting extremely concerned. He's like, "This does not sound like a recipe for a successful company." I remember thinking, "I wonder if Mark Zuckerberg ever sold collectable breakfast cereal." It turns out, never did. It was actually kind of a bad sign. But we just kept going. And I think the point of the story is that it's a year later, we spent tens of thousands of dollars, what did we rack up, like \$30,000 of credit card debt. We started selling collectable breakfast cereal. We launched three times. We got introduced to dozens of investors that weren't interested.

And that was the state when one night Michael says, "Come over to the office, Justin.tv." So Joe and I go to the office, and then we're kind of down. So the guys take us to a Thai restaurant in San Francisco. And it's Michael, I think it's the whole crew, Michael, Emmett, Justin, I think, and Kyle, the whole crew. And we're just depressed. And I remember Emmett saying, "Maybe you just need to identify what your viral coefficient is," and da da da da da. And I think Justin Khan just said, "You guys are dying. You should apply to Y Combinator." And I said, "Y Combinator? Y Combinator's for companies that haven't launched yet. We've launched. The New York Times wrote an article about me, we're a big deal."

And they're like, "You're a big deal that's dying. You are dying. Do YC." And so we go to the Y Combinator website, and on the Y Combinator website it turns out the application deadline was like the night before."

Jessica: Oh, God.

Brian: And I'm like, "No." And Michael's like, "Now you're definitely going to die. It's over now." And we're like, "No, it can't be possible. This can't be possible." So then Justin says, "All right, I'm going to email Paul Graham and see if I can get a 24-hour extension." So he emails Paul Graham, this is now 9:00 PM. Paul Graham writes back and he says, "We'll extend it, but I need the application by midnight tonight."

Now, I'm in West Coast time with Joe. Nate is in Boston with his fiancée. It's now midnight. And I said to Joe, "Let's divide and conquer. You need to convince Nate in the next two hours to join Y Combinator, if we get in, and then move across the country. I'll write the application." Of course, Joe then calls Nate. Nate agrees, although I think the next morning said, "What did I agree to again?" And then realized he had to explain to his fiancée that he agreed to move across country.

Jessica: Oh boy.

Brian: And that led to the interview with YC. And YC was the final shot. And I remember us before we even got into YC saying, "We're going to give this one more go. And at the end of YC, if we get in, we'll have a conversation. We will literally have a conversation about if we should keep working on this idea." And that led to us going to YC.

Jessica: Now, I remember the timing at this point had to have been November 2008.

Brian: Yeah.

Jessica: What was happening in the world around us back then?

Brian: Oh my God.

Jessica: World was cratering in.

Brian: The financial crisis.

Jessica: Yes.

Brian: I remember, oh, you're going to like this one. An investor, one of the investors told me, "The economy so bad I can't even invest in good companies right now. So why would I invest in Air Bed and Breakfast?"

Jessica: Wow.

Carolynn: Oh my God.

Brian: Like companies with revenue and customers. 'Cause even those companies can't raise money. You think you're going to get money for air beds?

Jessica: Well, okay, so that's what's happening. This is our third year of YC. We're still a very small potatoes type of deal. We were not that well known even in 2008, more well known when we started. And I was pregnant at the time and giving birth in January of 2009.

Brian: I remember getting to know you I think the first third of YC, and then, yeah, then I think ...

Jessica: I think I only missed two dinners. I think I only missed two dinners.

Brian: Oh, you did?

Jessica: Yeah. But anyway, it's the fall of 2008. And Paul and I said, "Gosh, we don't know if the winter batch is even going to be able to raise money at demo day, which is in March of 2009." That's many months in advance. So, we said, "We're only going to fund people who we think are so tough and possibly making a little money and can make it to Ramen profitability easily. And they have to be tough. So when you guys came in, I remember Paul didn't like your idea and he tried to convince you to do something else.

Brian: He tried to convince us to start Stripe.

Jessica: Oh, gosh. Okay. Well, at least it was a good alternative idea.

Brian: It was a good alternative idea. But it was basically like a bank, or he had this conceptual idea. And then hindsight I'm like, "Oh my God, he tried to get us to start Stripe." Which would have been a great idea, but wasn't our idea. And by the way, when we went down to the interview, Joe bought a box of Obama-Os, and Nate caught him packing the box. And Nate, as far as Nate's concerned, "Oh my God, this was a horrible nightmare detour that we were selling collectable breakfast cereal. And I'm glad we're back on track. We're building websites again." And Nate sees Joe packing the cereal box. He's like, "Please, Joe, just don't bring that." And Joe's like, "Okay, okay."

Jessica: Embarrassing.

Brian: But he still packed it in his bag.

Jessica: I'm so glad he did, because on the way out, the interview's like five minutes or something, 10 minutes.

Brian: Yeah, 10 minutes.

Jessica: You guys are walking out the door and Joe's like, "Oh wait, I'd like to leave these behind." And we started talking about the Obama-Os and Captain Crunch and all of that. And I remember you guys walked out the door and I remember thinking, "They designed these cereal boxes and stuffed fake Cheerios, off-brand Cheerios, and glue gunned it. These guys are tough. These guys are willing to do what it takes to survive."

Brian: If it wasn't for you, we might not have gone into Y Combinator.

Jessica: No.

Brian: Because Paul Graham admitted that he thought the idea was crazy. I think he liked us too. I wonder, if you weren't there, I don't know. I think you saw something, I like to think you saw something in us, and I think what Paul Graham described it later is that it was an investment nuclear winter and we were cockroaches.

Jessica: Yes, yes.

Brian: In other words, we wouldn't die. He was looking for people who wouldn't die. I said, "Well, I won't die. If it's a nuclear winter, I'll be the last thing dead." And so he's like, "You're a cockroach." And I thought that was the best thing ever. Paul Graham's a luminary and he said I was a cockroach. So I called my mom, I said, "This really famous investor just said I was a cockroach." And she's like ...

Jessica: Did he say that in the interview? Did he call you a cockroach in the interview?

Brian: No, later on, later on.

Jessica: Oh, okay, okay.

Brian: During YC. I'm pretty sure he said, "We're looking for cockroaches and you guys won't die." He might not have said, "You're a cockroach," but he said they're looking for cockroaches and you guys won't die. I think he maybe did say cockroaches or maybe we said it, but I was very proud of that label, cockroach.

Jessica: Well, you should be.

Brian: Oh, by the way, Jessica, do you remember that you also, the economy, just to remind people how bad it was, I recall it was way worse than today. Here's how bad it was.

Jessica: Oh, yeah.

Brian: It was so bad for startups that you offered to let people defer. Do you remember that?

Jessica: Yes.

Brian: You could say, "You can defer." So here's what you said, or Paul Graham said. "The economy's so bad, we don't know if investors will even show up for demo day. So if you want to defer, you can defer." And I believe a startup deferred. So that was just how bad it was. And there were like 12 or 14 companies in our batch.

Jessica: I don't even think that there were that ... Maybe there were 12, [inaudible 00:38:10] fewer, it was actually the one time we went down from the summer before. So we were really uncertain about what was going to happen. There was a lot of uncertainty. It was grim. But we loved you guys. We really thought you were a great team. And Paul called you that night to say, "We're going to fund you," right?

Brian: Yeah. You guys had this, I don't know if you still do this, but it's certainly a high anxiety tactic, where he says, "We're going to call you and let you know if you got in, then we'll tell you the terms." Although they're pretty much standard terms, "And you have to tell us on the spot if you want to do it or not." There's no thinking it through. And I'm like, "Okay, this is definitely a pretty structured thing."

Jessica: It's not an intimidation tactic. We gave everyone in advance the deal terms. So the only question was, "Do you want to do it?"

Brian: Yeah, yeah.

Jessica: We try to make things quick.

Brian: Yeah, yeah. I appreciate that. I think you guys were really founder friendly. For us though, it was like that Eminem movie Last Mile or Eight Mile, where this is our last shot and this is our whole life flashing before our eyes, and this is our final shot. It's a big life decision, actually. And so we're in a car, I get a call from, I see this number, maybe it was a 617 or something number, which looked like a Boston number, which I'm guessing was Paul. I don't know why I remember that, but I think I remember that. And I remember picking up the number and I go, "Hello?" He goes, "Hey Brian, this is Paul Graham. Can you talk?" And I go, "Yes, Paul." And he goes, "So Jessica and the partners and I talked, and ..." And then there's this long pause. And I'm like, "This is cruel." It's like those game shows where ... And then I realized, "Oh my God, I have an iPhone." It's late 2008 and I'm on the 280 where there was literally no service.

Jessica: No service.

Carolynn: Yeah.

Brian: So, I basically now, I'm in a dead spot for 10 minutes. And so all of a sudden I'm like, "No, no." And I didn't know he's like, "We need an answer right away." So I'm like, "Oh my God, what if they just went down the list? This is it." And so I'm like, "Go, go, go." And we're in this old red Jeep Cherokee that Joe had, and he had this old Jose Gonzalez mix tape that he played every time we got in the car for 10 years in a row. It was just the same song over and over and over and over again. And I wanted to scream at this moment. And I'm like, "Go, go." And it was like he turned the red Jeep Cherokee into the Batmobile and we were weaving through traffic to get back in the city. And by the time we get off the exit, we get back in the city south of Market, all of a sudden my phone rings again and it's him.

And I'm like, "Oh my God, oh my God, oh my God, we've got one more shot." I go, "Hello?" He goes, "All right, Brian." And he basically offers the terms and he goes, "Would you like to join Y Combinator?" And I go, "Hold on one second." And then I suddenly realized, "Oh my God, we have a lot of leverage here. Wait one second, you're going to wait for me." And I go to the guys and I go, "Wait a second. Do we have any other options?" They go, "No." I go, "All right, we'll take it. All right, we'll take it. We have zero leverage and we want to do Y Combinator, so who cares?"



So we ended up doing Y Combinator, and I know we're running out of time so I'll just say that we get to Y Combinator, and the day of Y Combinator Paul gives me the best and worst advice I've ever gotten in my life. The first piece of advice he gives is, "You have to move to Mountain View to start your company." That was the worst advice. That was totally crazy. You didn't need to live in Mountain View. But he followed it up with the best advice. It was a paraphrase from Paul [Buke 00:41:41], who I believe was on your podcast. And he basically drew on this whiteboard this shallow swimming pool. It was like a cross-section of the Washington pool. And then he did a cross-section of a well, and he said, "You want to basically have a few people who deeply love you."

So imagine just a few people and you go really deep in love. In other words, it's better to have 100 people that love you than a million people who sort of like your service. And this was totally counterintuitive, because what it meant is that you should do things that don't scale, focus on making something that somebody wants. In fact, make t-shirts, make something people want. And we thought, "We're overachievers. We want to make something people love and need." If I could just impart one product development piece of advice to everyone here, it would be, focus on designing something perfect for one person. Don't focus on designing something for a million people. Isn't there a writing exercise when you're writing, visualize writing to one person, not to this amorphous blob of people, and the writing is typically better?

Same thing with startups. Design the perfect experience. Imagine you're a storyboard artist and you're storyboarding the end-to-end experience of what the most astounding product and experience is. And I wouldn't worry about distribution, marketing, PR, anything like that, that comes later. Make sure you have a product so astounding that people talk about it. It's very easy to focus on making something great when you actually don't have too many customers. And actually growth, paradoxically, even in a network effect business like Airbnb, growth is often your worst enemy to making your product perfect. Because the moment you have a lot of growth, you have a lot of problems, and you're focused on putting out fires. And the time that you have to focus on making the product perfect is kind of out the window. Now you've got to answer customer service calls and make things improve. You have to fix bugs and you have to build an organization.

Here's what I would say. A lot of founders are frustrated probably, like, "Why aren't I raising money? Why don't I have more growth?" And I say, "Oh my God, I know you need some money to work on your product, but this is the golden moment. This is the golden era for you. This is the moment when you define your culture, you build something amazing." Because once it takes off, it's really hard to improve it. It's much harder than people think.

Jessica: Back to you being a designer, because I think that most people don't realize the connection, the importance of your and Joe's background as designers in your success. And specifically I'm going to talk about this idea of field work that you guys did.

Brian: Yes.

Jessica: You went to New York when you didn't have that many users. I remember Paul during YC said, "Well, where are most of your users?" And you're like, "New York's our biggest market." And he's like, "Well, what are you doing here?" And you guys got on a plane and you went out with your camera equipment that you had and you talked to your users, and you learned so much by just visiting them. And I think that if you hadn't have been designers, you might not have wanted to do or known to do that kind of field work, right?

Brian: Yeah. I talk about it like, there's the laboratory and there's going out in the field. And when you're in your home on a laptop coding or building something or designing something, you're really in the laboratory. In the laboratory you're making a bunch of assumptions of what people want. But the problem is that a lot of people don't actually get out in the world and they don't actually talk to the people. And remember, all you have to do is make something people want. That was what I learned from Y Combinator. Make something people love. And so you need to spend, in the early days you probably want to spend nearly as much time in the field as the lab. And so talk to your customers, become your customers, watch your customers.

When you bought an iPhone, Steve Jobs didn't come and sleep on your couch. But I did. I actually lived with our users. And by living with them, I noticed a bunch of things. I noticed, "Wow, this home is way nicer than the photos." And this is before phones had good cameras on them. So we developed this whole operation to photograph people's homes for them, which was, at the time it was almost like an Uber on-demand service before Uber. It was actually a pretty innovative little service. I could go down the list of things, but it's amazing what you can learn just by watching. There are so many subtle things about life that could be better if you slow down and you pay attention. And I think that one of the challenges in Silicon Valley is that we're very focused on growth. And I think that growth is critical. A startup that doesn't grow dies. But people need to keep remembering that mainly things grow because people love them and tell other people about them.

And that's the really simple thing. The simple thing is, make something that people love and go crazy. I would say make it almost, I understand the idea of an MVP, but I would say make it so crazy that people tell each other about it. Because it's really hard to get anyone to notice your product. It's really expensive to market. It's a really crowded field. And so you've just got to try to make something astoundingly cool. It doesn't have to do a ton, but it's got to be astoundingly cool. And it can't just be well-built. It's got to be something that people you know want. And I think this is counterintuitive to a lot of analytical people or computer science backgrounds, but to a designer it was totally normal to walk in someone's shoes and say, "I'm going to make this thing so much better than anything you've ever seen before."

And then we would go back. So we would commute from Mountain View to New York every single week during Y Combinator. And so Joe and I would go to New York City for a few days, be in the field living at users', get all this feedback, then we'd go back. We'd design, hand everything over to Nate, then he'd be building, then we go back to New York. And I think that rhythm is a great metaphor for what people should be doing in the early days. I think founders should be in the details. I would encourage people, have a

designer on their founding team, but even if you don't, remember, design isn't how something looks. It's how it fundamentally works. And so as a designer, you have to walk in people's shoes. You have to make the complex simple. You have to look at a holistic solution. And I think these are some of the things that you should do. And if you do all that and you build something people love, then they're going to tell each other about it and you're going to grow.

Jessica: I'm getting a little sad here, Brian, because I know we're coming up to when we have to end. And I feel like ...

Brian: Oh my God, I thought we were a quarter the way through.

Jessica: I didn't even get to ask any of the questions. We didn't even get to YC. I feel like someday you're going to have to come back and do Airbnb part two.

Brian: Well, why don't we make this part one?

Carolynn: Part one, yeah.

Brian: We'll have to invite, yeah, this is part one. Because honestly, we've only gotten started. And by the way, I'll just say this because I'm 15 years into this. I speak at nearly every Y Combinator dinner that I can.

Jessica: Yes.

Brian: And for years most of my YC talk was just the founding of the company. And I remember a few years ago I said to myself, "The craziest thing I ever did in my life and the craziest thing I'll ever do in my life was start Airbnb." And little did I know that something so much crazier than everything I just told you was about to unfold, which was the pandemic. We lost 80% of our business in eight weeks. People thought we were going out of business. And when you have a business like ours that was doing like \$35 billion, I believe at that point in bookings a year, and you lose 80% in eight weeks, it's like an airplane that's going to lose massive altitude.

It's like in '18 we were slamming on the brakes. Nothing good happens. Our business flashes before our eyes. And what came next was actually crazier than everything I just said. And maybe that could be the basis for part two. And also I would just say, I think that there's a whole bunch of lessons I've learned from the early days, which I shared some of them. But there's also, for people listening, after Y Combinator. What do you do after YC?

Jessica: Yeah.

Brian: What do you do when you're 20 people, 30 people, 50 people, 100 people? There's a whole journey there too.

Jessica: Yeah. Will you agree to do part two?

Brian: Let's do it.

Jessica: Because we didn't even it talk about COVID and how you've ...

Brian: Let's make this a serialized version. So this is part one.

Jessica: No pun unintended.

Brian: Part two. Yes, exactly. Yes, yes, I am a serial entrepreneur. And so we're just going to keep going until the story's complete.

Jessica: So it's just like this is just a pause. Because I didn't even get a chance to say how you were the model YC founder.

Brian: We're at the end of part one, part two will pick it up at YC, and then I think part three is the crisis.

Jessica: Yes, I love this. I can't promise the listeners what the timing will be on these, but we're going to do it.

Brian: Yeah, yeah. Let's say in the next, we'll do it in month or so. Is that okay? Is that too much gap?

Jessica: No, it doesn't matter, whatever you can.

Brian: Okay.

Jessica: We'll do it. Because I also have to say just how proud we are, how proud I am and we are, and I'm going to start to cry because I always cry. I'm crying when I see these successful founders who I knew back when they were doing YC, and I'm just so excited for you. And I really want to hear the rest of all the stories. And just last question that Carolyn and I were talking about before you got on, is now that you're a public company CEO and all that, what do you enjoy doing in your spare moments? You must not have that much free time.

Carolynn: Yeah, what makes you happy personally? Completely apart from Airbnb?

Brian: I'll end with one big thought. This is a really big thought, though.

Jessica: Okay.

Brian: And maybe I'll talk about this a little more in the part two, but here it is. And this is a kind of heavy thing. Nobody told me how lonely it would become at times to start a company. When I started Airbnb, Airbnb was like my family. The employees you hang out with, you go to bars together, and they're your friends. There's not really this sense that they're your ... When you start a company and you're five, 10 people, they're not really your employees. They're your friends that you work with and you all have equity, you're

hardly making any money. And then one day you wake up, if you're successful, and it is shockingly isolating and lonely to be a CEO of a large company. But it doesn't look like you'd be lonely because you're surrounded by people all day. The more successful you are, the more people are you're surrounded with but the more isolated you feel, because the fewer people share the context that you have. The buck stops with you.

And this is how I felt before the crisis. And the other thing is that I am 41 and a lot of my friends that are my age have families. My parents had me when they were 30. A little bit of my personal life was kind of on hold. Airbnb was completely consuming. And one day I remember waking up in late 2019 feeling like, "Wow, life is a little lonely. I need to make some changes." And then the pandemic occurs and it's even worse. And then suddenly over the course of 2020, I was working basically 16 hours a day, seven days a week. And I didn't feel like I was talking to people all day, but it was just work. And some point I realized by 2021, "I've got to be careful that this is not the rest of my life. Because I've had all this success, but what's the point of being incredibly successful if you're also going to be really alone?"

And separately, I'd started studying loneliness. And the reason why was, this is a crazy story, I hired as a contract consultant the Surgeon General of the United States. The current Surgeon General for President Biden was also Surgeon General for Barack Obama. And we hired him because it was a pandemic, we wanted the homes to be sanitized, and we thought this person could give a seal of approval for what would be a good protocol. But in getting to know him, I realized he had written a book during his first administration, and his book was about what he believed was the number one killer in America. And people think the number one killer in America is either obesity, cardiac disease, or cancer. And he said, "Well, not exactly." His opinion, the number one killer in America was loneliness.

Jessica: No.

Brian: That if you look at depression, you look at suicide, you look at obesity, the opioid crisis, that there was a dark threat. It's not that all addiction comes from loneliness, but that a large amount of people, a lot of these ailments also happen to have weak social connections. And that being lonely takes 15 years off your life. It is like smoking a pack of cigarettes a day. And this is what he said before the pandemic. And so why is this happening? Well, the mall is now Amazon, the theater is now Netflix, the restaurant is now DoorDash, the office is now Zoom. And each one of these changes is great. I love every one of those products. But we have to be very careful as a society that we don't design a world where every small innovation is a step forward for humanity, or we think it is, but then there's a larger context where we're alone.

And I learned that the loneliest people in America, you know who they are? Teenage girls. Teenage girls are lonelier than people in nursing homes. And that two out of three teenagers between 18 and 25 are lonely some or all of the time. And so this became a personal mission for me, and we could talk about it more in part two, but I said, "Wow, if I'm going to address this, I have to start with myself." And so I started just really becoming intentional about, think about all the people in my life. Because I actually had a lot of friends, but I didn't really maintain a lot of relationships. And so I started

rekindling relationships with my friends. I started rekindling relationships from my college friends, high school friends, others.

And the last thing I'll say about loneliness is, loneliness is something I thought people that are at the end of their life experience. It's actually a feeling everyone experiences. If you don't experience loneliness at one point in your life, you're probably not human. Loneliness doesn't mean you're alone, you're not in a relationship or marriage. Loneliness, you need concentric circles. You need to be connected to yourself, to a family typically, to friends, typically 10, 15 relationships, to a larger community of 100, 150 people, this is the Dunbar rule, and what we call the cosmos, a sense of something bigger than yourself. Whether it's the tech industry or your country or your sports team. And you need really varying levels of connection. And I think that we're starting to live in a world where increasingly more of our time is spent online. The average American today spends 10 more hours alone than 10 years ago. Every year the average American is spending an extra year alone than the year before.

I think this is a really big issue. There's this old, "What do you think is true that everyone disagrees with you about?" My thing is that I think loneliness will rival global warming in the 21st century as a major problem. And I think it's the least talked about problem in the world. Sorry, this is a really heavy answer, but it goes back to where I want to re-pivot the company. Because during the wake of the crisis, which we'll talk a little bit more later, when our business flashed before my eyes, I said, "We need to focus on something that's going to really help people. The thing we can do is we're not going to solve this problem, but I want to bring it back to its roots and help regular people connect together." And so the long story short is, I started my own life. I got really intentional about rekindling relationships with friends.

Jessica: Yep.

Brian: It really helped a lot. I still feel a little loneliness, but it's a lot better. And then for the company we've got some really cool things coming up that hopefully help continue to bring people together. And I think that's something that drives me now, that it always has been in the background, but I think there's an imperative that's greater now. And I think that Airbnb, what's different about us than other technology companies is, we sit at the intersection of technology and design, of technology and the humanities. And so I think that we're a company that's uniquely suited for problems that are rooted in people and their relationship to other people. And so that's where we sit. That's what one of the things we're focused on.

Jessica: You bring people together for sure.

Brian: That's what we're trying to do.

Carolynn: All right. We'd better let you go back to your day job.

Jessica: But we are all going to see each other in person in less than in three weeks, on that note.

Brian: Yeah, I'll see you in three weeks. And I promise we'll do a part two. And who knows, maybe we'll just keep going. But I have too much to say to end the podcast here, so we've got to do a little bit more.

Jessica: All right, part two. Thank you so much, Brian.

Brian: I'm sure Paul's like, "What did you agree to do? This is going to be awful."

Jessica: He's going to be so mad at you, but you agreed to part two and part three, we've already laid out the format.

Brian: I know. I know. Maybe it should be a 10-episode series and it just goes on and on and on and we just keep going. I can literally go day by day, like, "2014. It was a Tuesday."

Jessica: Chronological, no, we'll go chronological. All right.

Brian: Exactly.

Jessica: It's so great to see you and hear your voice and hear all your stories. Thank you again for your time.

Carolynn: Thank you, Brian.

Brian: Thank you, Carolynn, I can't wait to see you in person. All right, bye.

Carolynn: Okay, bye.

Jessica: Carolynn, that was so much fun.

Carolynn: Wow. That was. So it was fun and it was also so heavy at the end.

Jessica: I know.

Carolynn: I think that honestly, that was the least surprising answer, I think, with lots of amazing, interesting stuff packed into it. But yeah, I've heard a lot of people say that the CEO job is super lonely, but also loneliness in general. I know that that's ...

Jessica: It's lonely at the top.

Carolynn: It's lonely.

Jessica: I mean, it's a cliché.

Carolynn: It is lonely at the top.

Jessica: But that's so interesting. I didn't realize he was so interested in ... I know he's always been a connector. It's like a defining characteristic of him. And it goes back to RISD when

he was bringing people together with the hockey team or whatever, or the basketball team, I forget which one he and Joe had. It's a defining quality of him to bring people together, to connect people. And so I can see why he's so fascinated with loneliness. I have to admit, I hate ending on a bit of a sad and serious note.

Carolynn: That would have been a good ending for maybe part three. Two other nuggets just to point them out. The point about, design is not how it looks, but how it operates, or I don't remember what his exact words were. That's something that Gary has been saying a lot too, and I don't think it really sunk in until Brian said it, that it's like, yeah, you think of design as just the outside, the exterior of something, but it's so much deeper than that. Super important.

Jessica: It is not just a head count, it is how you connect with your users.

Carolynn: Yeah. Yeah, super important. And then the other nugget that Brian said about growth and growing too fast, and I feel like I could make a list of 100 companies that got too much money and grew too fast and had exactly the problem that Brian was describing.

Jessica: Oh, 100%.

Carolynn: Yeah.

Jessica: I'm just sad because I have so many questions I wanted to ask him and we didn't even scratch the surface.

Carolynn: I know.

Jessica: There's so much and there's so many raisins in that scone.

Carolynn: Yeah. It's 15 years, so of course.

Jessica: Yeah.

Carolynn: So it'll be really great to talk to him again.

Jessica: In part two. And he is committed. We've got him.

Carolynn: Yeah, on tape, recorded.

Jessica: So I don't know when we'll do it, but we'll come back with part two and part three if need be.

Carolynn: Yeah.

Jessica: But I just love his stories, and I do think they help illustrate some important themes, like just how much determination you have to have and just how long it takes. And it's a long game.



Carolynn: No, he really is the poster child for all of those themes that we talk about and has a great way to weave them all together too, which is really interesting.

Jessica: Should I be embarrassed that I always get a little choked up when they're talking about how successful they are?

Carolynn: No. No.

Jessica: I remember ...

Carolynn: Don't be embarrassed.

Jessica: ... Years ago I went to this lunch, and Bill Clinton was there and he was talking. Brian was there and Bill Clinton was talking to him, and I think Patrick Collison and Drew Houseton. And I remember I was just looking at the three of them talking to Bill Clinton, and I got all teary-eyed thinking, "Bill Clinton's just talking to these three young people that we funded and I'm so proud of them." I just can't help it.

Carolynn: Yeah, no, that's a super human reaction. So I don't think you should be embarrassed.

Jessica: Well, it was a fun conversation to have with him, as always, and we'll look forward to part two.

Carolynn: Yep, exactly.

Jessica: All right.

Carolynn: All right.

Jessica: Talk to you later. Bye.

Carolynn: Bye.